

The Campsite

The Friends

We had just arrived at the campsite. After setting up our tents, we cleared the area where we would make the fire that night. *Finally*, I thought to myself.

James poked his head out of his tent and asked, “Did you say something?”

I told him I was just excited to finally be here. Months of planning and hours of driving, and we had finally made it to Shadow Valley National Park.

Surrounding our campsite were towering trees the size of buildings, a crystal-clear lake, and the start of a hiking trail that led to the top of the park—offering a breathtaking view of the entire landscape.

Nothing eventful happened on the first day. But on the second, we woke up early and went on the

hike. Jake and Natasha stayed behind—too hungover from drinking the night before—but John, Emma, and I completed the entire 12-kilometer trail. It was so worth it. While we were at the top, we took photos, had a small picnic, and just admired the beauty of where we were.

Back at the campsite, we all went swimming in the park's famous lake: *Moonlit Shores*. During the day, the water is crystal clear, as I mentioned. But at night, something strange happens—the moonlight reflects in a way that creates illusions of fish swimming. It's a sight to behold.

Later that night, as we sat around the fire in eerie silence, we heard a sound. It was faint—like someone trying to move quietly through the trees.

Jake and I stood up to check it out. He shone his flashlight toward the woods, but we saw nothing. The noises continued though, shifting from tree to tree. Then, suddenly, we caught a glimpse of something—someone. It looked like a person, but with a wolf-like appearance.

We were startled, but oddly, we returned to the campfire and tried to laugh it off. That is, until Natasha stopped mid-sentence and slowly pointed behind us.

As Jake and I turned around, we saw it. A creature. A werewolf—but not like the ones from movies or folklore. This thing was around six feet tall and still carried a faint resemblance to a human. Or what used to be one.

Instinct took over—we ran. The creature snarled behind us. I could hear it chasing us, its growls echoing through the trees. Then Natasha tripped, likely over a rock. I turned just in time to see it pounce on her. It grabbed her head, placed it beside her lifeless body with unsettling care, and then turned its attention back to the rest of us.

I screamed for everyone to head to the car. We all scattered.

After what felt like an eternity, I made it to the car. Moments later, Jake and Emma arrived—both out of breath, panicked—but there was no sign of John.

I didn't wait. I yelled for them to get in or be left behind. As we sped away, I glanced in the rearview mirror and saw the creature stepping out of the woods, holding what I can only assume were the heads of Natasha and John. It let out a grotesque howl and watched as we disappeared down the road.

At the park entrance, we were met by a ranger. He asked why we looked so pale, so shaken. We told him what happened, and he simply said it was better to leave them. He explained that others had tried to hunt the creature—but they always suffered the same fate. One ranger would vanish, and the rest would return so badly injured they could never walk again.

The car ride home was dead silent—not a single word, not even a cough. When we pulled into the driveway, we just sat there. None of us moved. That's when the tears started. We knew we would never see them again.

We never told anyone the truth. To those who asked, we simply said: *"They went on a hike and never came back."*

From the Beast

It was like any other day. **Boring.** That was until a new group of friends arrived at *my* park.

Well, they call it a "national park" now—"protected land" or whatever. But to me, it's *mine*. Has been for decades.

What never changes, no matter how much time passes, is the stupidity of those who come here. They pitch their cloth triangles near *my* lake and try to stay the night. They don't understand the danger.

That lake they love so much—Moonlit Shores—sure, it's beautiful. Especially at night. The illusions created by the moonlight are mesmerizing. But those illusions drive people mad. They go into a kind of frenzy... a rage. They try to tear down the forest. To hurt *my* home.

So I do what I must. I kill them. Or scare them away.

Back to this group. They arrived and set up camp like the rest. The first night, they just drank and laughed. No harm done.

The next day, only three of them hiked the trail. It's a beautiful trail, honestly. I'd recommend it—if you were allowed to leave after.

That second night, they went swimming in the lake. That's when the madness started. I watched. Waited. Tried to just follow, maybe scare them. But then one saw me—and they all ran.

I chased them.

One of them fell. I caught her. Ended her quickly—removed her head and placed it beside her, neatly. It's not personal. It's necessary.

The others had split up. I sniffed out one hiding nearby. He met the same end.

As I returned to the forest's edge, the last ones were escaping in a box with round feet that roared as it fled. I let out a howl. A warning. My voice cracked, but I think they understood.

I took the two I caught back to my home. Some people call it a "cave." I call it safety.

I placed their heads on the pile. My trophy pile. A reminder that I'm doing what I must.

Might need to start a second pile soon.

As I rested and looked out over the lake, I saw something in the distance.

Another group.

I haven't been this excited in years.

Alden Esterhuizen

April 2025